

Findings from the round translation process

Task 6 – English/Polish

The analysis of the translation data reveals a range of common mistake types, many of which significantly affect the meaning, tone, or grammaticality of the output. These mistakes occur at different stages — some during the initial translation from English to Polish, and others during the back translation from Polish to English.

One prominent category is lexical and word choice errors. These typically occur in the first translation to Polish, where words are either translated too literally or replaced with overly general or misleading synonyms. For example, "companions" becomes "comrades," and "lingerie" is simplified to "underwear." Such choices often lose the tone or nuance of the original, and though they may seem close in meaning, the connotations are off, especially in informal or stylized contexts.

Idiomatic expressions present another major challenge, usually in the Polish translation. Phrases like "kill it" or "work cut out for me" are translated literally, leading to completely changed meanings. This is a common linguistic issue when figurative language is translated word-for-word, ignoring the idiom's actual function.

Tone and register shifts are frequently introduced during both stages but are especially noticeable in back translations. Informal/slang, emotional expressions such as "yeah" or "let's do this" are transformed into more formal or neutral equivalents like "oh, that's right" or "let's get on with it." This indicates a tendency to lose conversational style and natural flow, which is important in spoken content.

Grammatical errors, including subject-verb agreement and awkward structure, often originate in the transcribed version, get translated to Polish and carry over into back translation. For instance, mistranslations like "I am Filipinos" or awkward restructuring of tenses reflect poor alignment with grammatical norms in either language.

Omissions or additions, like dropping key words ("runways") or inserting new phrases ("How are you?"), appear in both directions, but are more common in back translations. These shifts often stem from attempts to smooth out or "complete" a sentence, resulting in added meaning or loss of detail.

Gender and pronoun shifts — such as "she" becoming "he" or "her walk" turning into "when he walks" — are significant errors that typically occur in the back translation, when the Polish translation doesn't explicitly mention the subject of the sentence. These issues may arise from ambiguity or from limitations in the translation process where gendered references are not clearly maintained.

In conclusion, while both translation directions contribute to errors, the majority of meaning-altering mistakes originate in the first translation to Polish, particularly in lexical choice, idiomatic handling, and grammatical structure. Back translations tend to introduce tonal shifts or emphasize formality, often flattening the expressive and conversational elements of the original English.